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Writing women's worlds

Author(S): Abu-Lughod, Lila**Document Type:** Book**Original Page:** 24**Culture (OWC):** [Libyan Bedouin \(MT09\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Northern Africa**Field Date:** 1978-1989**Coverage Date:** 1978-1989**Place Coverage:** Western Desert, Egypt**Section Title(S):** Storytelling

Piety and religious observance have positive meanings for all the women in this Bedouin community, whereas to many secular people they suggest a certain sobriety, if not humorlessness. For old Migdim, however, piety—expressed through such practices as organizing her daily schedule around prayer and praising God even as she moans about her arthritic hands—does not seem to preclude chuckling over a risqué folktale, enjoying a sexually explicit song, or energetically bad-mouthing a neighbor.²⁹

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In addition to these qualities, both believers and outside scholars grant Islam a sort of timeless and supralocal existence. Yet whether we take the view of those in the Bedouin community, who see truth in the Qur'an and the model of the Prophet and strive to follow them, or of the outsider, who reifies a set of complex practices and statements in a notion like "the religion of Islam," we fail to grasp the real dilemmas people face because of Islam's grounding in social and historic specifics. The Awlad 'Ali women whose stories fill this book have been shaken up in the last decade by their indirect contact with members of the new Islamic movements in Egypt and their association with Egyptian state institutions like schools and media where new moral claims about the "good Muslim" are made. Educated daughters argue with their mothers about traditional practices, backing their positions by referring to Egyptian orderliness and employing knowledge of religion. The older women now wonder whether they are wrong to visit the tombs of saints or to seek out holymen to write amulets, as some people in the towns tell them, people who go to the  25 mosque and can read the Qur'an—and have beards, the women sometimes joke irreverently, that resemble public hair.

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29. For a discussion of the tension between the Islamic discourse and other discourses in this Bedouin community and a sense of how to analyze these tensions, see my "Islam and the Gendered Discourses of Death" (forthcoming).

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